

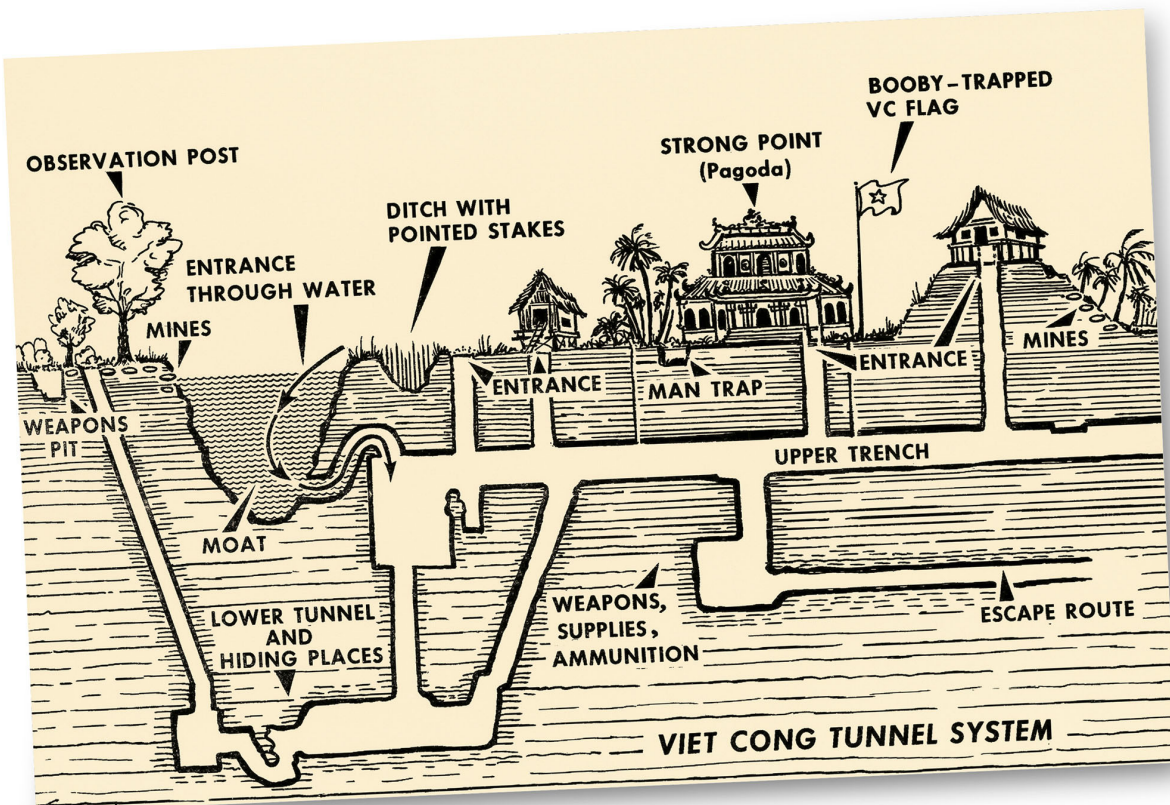
The tunnel rats

Mapping and clearing the tunnels were lethal for the American, South Vietnamese, and Australian soldiers who braved darkness, the danger of getting lost, and booby traps, especially when they ventured into a tunnel for the first time or dropped through a trap door between two levels of a tunnel system. They might be impaled by punji sticks—sharpened lengths of bamboo—stung by scorpions, or bitten by snakes tied to stakes in the roof. Early attempts to use dogs instead of people were soon abandoned, as dogs could not detect traps. Other precautions, such as using smoke to detect openings, or clearing tunnels with grenades had the drawback of alerting the enemy or destroying valuable intelligence.

An Australian combat engineer, Sandy MacGregor, is credited with being the first to discover the extent of the Cu Chi tunnels, an underground warren that spread for miles in the Iron Triangle northwest of Saigon. He coined the term “tunnel ferret” to refer to Australian soldiers charged with clearing tunnels, while Americans with the same duties were “tunnel rats.”

Some American tunnel rats were members of the First Infantry and 25th Infantry divisions who operated in teams of up to 13 men; others were ad hoc volunteers; they all had to be small, as the tunnels were tight. Two men went into a tunnel at one time; the job of the second man was to radio coordinates to the surface so that the tunnels could be mapped.

■ 17 The number of babies born in the tunnels of Vinh Moc during the course of the war.



Mapping the tunnels

This diagram, dating from 1966, is an American representation of a tunnel network. US training bases built tunnel systems to help prepare their troops. In reality, the tunnels were more complex, with many entrances and booby traps.